

The Right to Roam: Access to the Countryside [B2]

Poche cose ci fanno stare bene come lo stare in contatto con la natura. In Gran Bretagna, però, il “diritto di vagare” non è per niente scontato.

Nature is essential for our physical and mental [wellbeing](#). What's more, research shows that without a physical connection to the natural world, we're [less likely](#) to care about it or act to protect it. Across Europe, especially Northern Europe, many countries have a legal 'freedom to [roam](#)'; this means that the public have the right to [wander around](#) their countryside and can freely enjoy their natural environment, as long as their activities are non-commercial.

NOT ALLOWED

But in Britain the public has a very limited right to access land. Only about eight per cent of England and Wales, much of it remote and very little of it around urban areas, are open access. In the southeastern county of Kent, for example, only 0.6 per cent of its beautiful green landscape is open access. And even under the UK's new Countryside and [Rights of Way Act](#) 2000 (known as the CROW [Act](#)) the British right to [roam](#) does not generally allow camping, fishing, swimming, kayaking or even cycling.

KINDER SCOUT

In 1932, four hundred [hikers](#) made history when they trespassed on Derbyshire [moorland](#) and [climbed](#) to the [summit](#) of Kinder Scout. The organisers faced violence and were sent to prison, but their action led to the formation of Britain's National Parks and the introduction of the 1949 Countryside [Act](#).

PURE NEPOTISM

So, why does Britain decline to allow its citizens access to their own countryside? Look to its history of feudal land [ownership](#), dating back to 1066 and the Norman Conquest. When William I conquered Britain, he declared all land belonged to the Crown and [rewarded](#) his Norman barons and supporters with land in return for their loyalty. The Domesday Book, compiled in 1086, documented land [ownership](#) and value for [taxation](#) purposes.

KEEP OUT!

Today, the UK Crown (the monarch and government) still owns all land in England and in Wales. People own land either directly or indirectly via the Crown (for example, a [freehold estate](#) or a [leasehold estate](#).) Vast areas of UK land are managed for landowners by farmers, [foresters](#), [gamekeepers](#) and estate managers. [Fences](#), [barbed wire](#), and “Keep out” and “[Trespassers will be prosecuted](#)” signs are [widespread](#). Apart from public [footpaths](#) and rights of way or ‘permissive access’ [granted](#) by landowners, entry to most British land (and water) is prohibited.

PRISONERS

Through the centuries, a succession of acts, such as [game and hunting](#) laws and [enclosure acts](#), have [even further](#) restricted public access to Britain’s land and wildlife. The UK currently [ranks bottom](#) of the league for nature connectedness across Europe. British children now spend less time outdoors than prisoners! But while there are few signs that the UK government will expand the right to [roam](#) anytime soon, Britons are still looking for ways to explore the British landscape, its lovely woodlands, riversides and [grasslands](#). Campaign groups, such as Greenpeace, Right to Roam, and the [Ramblers](#), are [speaking up](#) for the people, demanding increased and more equal access to the UK countryside. www.righttoroam.org.uk

Glossary

- **widespread** = diffusi, sparsi
- **ranks bottom** = essere all'ultimo posto
- **hikers** = escursionisti
- **summit** = cima, vetta
- **leasehold estate** = locazione a lungo termine
- **foresters** = guardie forestali
- **Fences** = recinzioni
- **prosecuted** = perseguire legalmente
- **less likely** = meno portati
- **wander around** = passeggiare, girovagare
- **climbed** = scalare
- **gamekeepers** = guardiacaccia
- **game and hunting** = selvaggina e caccia
- **even further** = ancora di più
- **Ramblers** = escursionisti
- **Rights of Way** = diritti di passaggio
- **moorland** = brughiera
- **Act** = legge
- **roam** = vagare
- **rewarded** = ricompensare
- **wellbeing** = benessere
- **ownership** = proprietà
- **taxation** = tassazione
- **footpaths** = sentieri pedonali
- **enclosure acts** = leggi sulle recinzioni
- **grasslands** = praterie
- **freehold estate** = proprietà fondiaria piena e illimitata
- **barbed wire** = filo spinato
- **Trespassers** = intrusi, trasgressori
- **granted** = concedere
- **speaking up** = farsi sentire, parlare apertamente